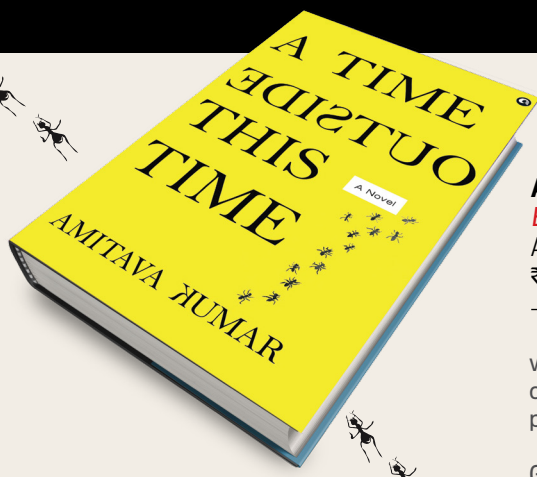


Sense of an Ending

EVEN AS AMITAVA KUMAR'S NOVEL ASKS IF FICTION HAS A ROLE TO PLAY IN OUR LIVES STILL, HIS WRITING SAYS YES

A TIME OUTSIDE THIS TIME
By Amitava Kumar
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
₹699; 226 pages

In Amitava Kumar's *A Time Outside This Time*, his 11th book, three engrossing stories are nestled in a meta-narrative of "writing about writing" during the current era of authoritarianism's anti-individualism and the Covid-19 pandemic's social distancing. And though the author has a different identity from the writer, it is clearly Kumar's alter-ego that is named Satya, given the book's preoccupations. Satya is at a creative getaway in Italy when Covid hits, searching for the answer to "Who among your neighbours will look the other way when a figure of authority comes to your door and puts a boot in your face?"

Satya is simultaneously reading George Orwell's *1984*, a fashionable read in the age of surveillance capitalism and strongman politics. His interactions echo the hesitant human response to the rapidly spreading Covid. The slow-motion collapse of civilisation makes the author/ writer wonder: does fiction have a role any longer?

His first tale is of left-wing extremist Kundan, whom Satya is able to interview at a police camp in rural Bengal because the successful officials are from Bihar, one being a classmate of Satya's. Clearly, his access comes through privilege; unspoken is that it comes from a caste commonality. Satya's report, however, provides a twist in the tale.

The second is of his Delhi-based sister-in-law Shikha whose maid Jamuna is infected during the lockdown. Shikha takes in Jamuna's daughter Purnima, in preparation for exams. The building's residents, however, have strategised over WhatsApp and call the police, who take Shikha and Purnima into detention.

In the third, Satya's students participate in a Black Lives Matter protest in his college town (Kumar teaches at Vassar College in Poughkeepsie, New York) and afterwards, at a coffee shop, are confronted (in debate) by two white supremacists. To student Ishaan, that incident proves more valuable than all the classes he has taken, like Satya-taught "literature of 9/ 11" and "immigrant literature".

Satya explores not just fake news and anti-science, but also the equally damaging "soft" science. Vaani is a psych researcher, and psychology was once derided by the philosopher Karl Popper as pseudo-science. Such science, writes Kumar, with its misguided questions and conclusions does as much damage as "alternative facts".

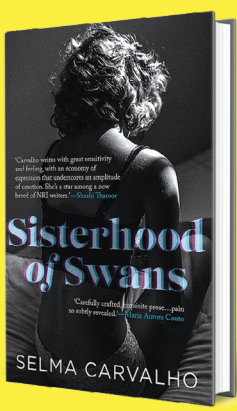


Though author Amitava Kumar has a different identity from the writer Satya, it is clearly an alter-ego

Kumar writes cleanly, directly and effortlessly. He does not rant or resort to purple prose. Hence, his is a worthwhile meditation on the zeitgeist.

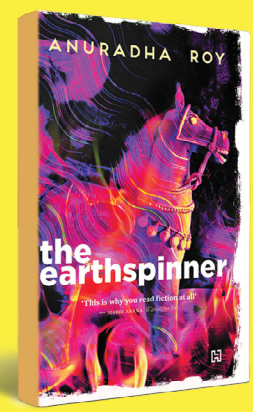
Unresolved is the initial question. Perhaps because of how "banal is the banality of evil", and perhaps because the jackboot is something like Steve Bannon's "flooding the zone with shit". But then, reading Orwell, Satya comes to literature's relevance: "an expression of a tiny will to freedom", a remembrance of the past that the State tries to obliterate, of "a time outside this time". ■

–Aditya Sinha



SISTERHOOD OF SWANS
by Selma Carvalho
SPEAKING TIGER
₹499; 184 pages

It is always a risk to put a farouche character at the centre of a novel. Carvalho finally raises the curtain on the lives of the diasporic Indian and the result is disturbing because you feel like you are entering the consciousness of a young woman who sees far too clearly for anyone's good.



THE EARTHSPINNER
by Anuradha Roy
HACHETTE INDIA
₹599; 232 pages

Anuradha Roy serves up prose that is lapidary in its precision, elegant in its execution and which does not allow beauty to cloud the horror of the present. This is a book I read slowly to make it last.